

Colossians 3:16 & Ephesians 5:19

Colossians: "Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly as you teach and admonish one another with all wisdom, and as you sing psalms, hymns and spiritual songs with gratitude in your heart to God."

Ephesians: "Speak to one another with psalms, hymns and spiritual songs. Sing and make music in your heart to the Lord."

*In order to fully understand these two scriptures one must be familiar with how they would have been interpreted by the first readers. Then we must come to an understanding of how key words from the passage were understood. Finally, what this all means to days believers.*

The church in Ephesus was a church on the front lines of battling cultic beliefs. The worshipping of unseen beings and powers other than the God of the Old Testament and the New Testament traditionally furnished the background of Paul's reasons for writing this Epistle. The city of Ephesus was the center for the pagan practices especially the worshipping of the goddess ARTEMIS (DIANA). It was also the home to a temple for worshipping the Roman emperor and his family.

Paul wrote in order to remind the early believers not to be foolish in their walk, but to walk in the enabling powers of the Spirit so that there would be harmony with one another in the fear of Christ. The early believers were to reflect God's truth and will in their daily walk with Him.

The church in Colossae on the other hand was fighting its battles from within. The church was dealing with heresy but since Paul had been imprisoned Epaphras informed Him of the developing heresy that was plaguing the church.

In response to these false teachings Paul warns the Colossians not to be misled by such philosophy. He presents the superiority of Christ, that is, his person, his saving work, and his complete sovereignty over the "emanations" (the so-called principalities and powers). Paul was saying that it was through Christ alone that they would overcome the indwelling of sin.

Just like the early church we too fight a similar battle. Each congregation must fight external and internal battles in order to retain and birth the promise that is rightfully ours. The battle each congregation faces is as unique as the lines in our hands.

The theological implications of Ephesians 5:19 lie in the preceding verse 5:18 (b). "Instead, be filled with the Spirit." It is clear that Ephesians 5:18 (b) and 5:19 is a command for all Christians. From the perspective of daily living and a vital Christian experience, the filling of the Spirit is undoubtedly the most important aspect of this doctrine. In essence, it is the basic requirement for growth and maturity.

The results of being filled with the spirit are that there will be harmony with one another, with God and submission to one another in the fear of the Lord.

- (1). Being filled with the Spirit will result in harmony with one another through spiritual singing (psalms, hymn and spiritual songs)
- (2). Being filled with the Spirit will result in harmony with God as one sings with one's heart and gives thanks for all things in the name of Christ to the Father. 5:19b

The present tense of this phrase rules out any once-for-all reception of the Spirit but points to a continuous replenishment. Paul is urging his readers to continue being filled. Keep on being filled is a good way to translate it. This is illustrated in the experience of the apostles during the early months of the church. Like wise, the Christian life today should be an uninterrupted filling. What this verse will not substantiate is the claim that after becoming a Christian, a single, additional, definitive filling is essential for completion. Repeated fillings may be necessary because new areas of life come to light which need to be brought under the control of the Spirit. Not to mention that when sin breaks the control the need for a Christians to be filled is imperative.

The implication here is that it should be done with "an earnest affection of the heart, and not with the tongue only." There are at least four results or characteristics of a spirit-filled life.

- 1.) Christ likeness, for the fruit of the Spirit
- 2.) Is Worship and praise, followed immediately by a statement of the consequences of being filled-singing and being thankful.
- 3.) Is submissiveness- Spirit control affects all the relationships of life so that proper harmony will be experienced.
- 4.) Lastly, we are to be filled in order to be of service to the Lord.

As a side note each one of these expression has to do with praise.

Similarly, the appeal that Colossians 3:16 made had to do largely with the duties that Christians owe one another. Verse 16 focuses on matters that have to do more directly with the personal life. The thought of our duty to others is not entirely absent.

To the early believers the scriptures attest to God's presence, activity, and love, particularly as expressed in his son, Jesus Christ. It brought to their attention, in a concrete and graphic manner, God's personal and loving commitment to his people. And as such, the Scriptures moved them to worship-individually and corporately.

It is apparent that the key to gaining a fuller understanding of the Ephesians 5:19 and Colossians 3:16 lies in its key words. Upon a closer look into the passage the verb "*to speak*" is not confined to normal conversation but covers utterance of any kind.

- 1) "*One another*" Transliterated Word- Heautou which means: himself, herself, itself, themselves
- 2) (To yourselves)---"to one another"
- 3) "*Psalms*" seems to refer to the OT Psalter, which was integrated with Christian worship.

- A.) Transliterated word- Psalmos which means a striking, twanging
  - B.) Of a striking the chords of a musical instrument
  - C.) Of a pious song, a psalm
    - a.) General accompanied by an instrument
- 4) *"Hymns"* in pagan circles were sung to eulogize some god or cultic hero. Christian hymns exalted the name of Christ (v19) or God (v20).
  - A.) Transliterated word-Hymnos which means a song in tithe praise of gods, heroes, conquerors.
  - B.) a sacred song, hymn
    - a.) In direct praise to God.
- E.) *"Spiritual songs"* May be so designated either to differentiate them from secular composition or because they represent spontaneous singing in the spirit.
  - A.) Transliterated word-Ode Pneumatikos which means a song, lay, ode.
    - a.) The general term for lyric pieces; "spiritual" is added to mark their being here restricted to sacred subject, though not merely to direct praises to God, but also containing exhortations, prophecies.
- 5) *"To make music"* can mean to play a stringed instrument or singing praise to the accompaniment of a harp.
  - A.) Transliterated word-Psallo which means to pluck off, pull out
  - B.) To cause to vibrate by touching, to twang
  - C.) To touch or strike the chord, to twang the strings of a musical instrument so that they gently vibrate
  - D.) To play on a stringed instrument, to play
  - E.) To sing to the music of the harp
  - F.) In the NT to sing hymn, to celebrate the praises of God in song
- 6) *"In your heart"* (melody) means not merely with the tongue; but the serious feeling of the heart accompanying the singing of the lips. The contrast is between the heathen and the Christian practice, "Let your songs be not the drinking songs of heathen feasts, but psalms and hymns; and their accompaniment, not the music of the lyre, but the melody of the heart.
- 7) *"To the Lord"* – it does not need to be heard by men but by Christ as God.

Further study in Colossians 3:16 revealed the Alexandrian copy and Arabic version of *"Let the word of Christ dwell in you..."* read, "The word of God"; which meant the whole Scripture, all the writings of the Old and New Testament, which were inspired by God. They were endited by the spirit of Christ, speak and testify of him, and were written for his sake, and on his account, and therefore called his word;

The term *"dwell in"* in its original contexts meant it had a place in them through the spirit and power of Christ; and that it should have a constant and fixed place there, and not be like a

stranger or wayfaring man, that tarries but for a night, or like a sojourner, that continues but for a while; but as an inhabitant that takes up its residence and abode, never more to depart; and intends not only a frequent reading, and hearing of, and meditating upon the word of God but continuance in the doctrines of the Gospel, with a steady faith in them, and a hearty affection for them; for such an inhabitation imports a very exact knowledge of the Gospel, and familiarity with it, and affectionate respect for it; as persons that dwell in a house, they are well known by those of the family, they are familiarly conversed with, and are treated with love and respect by them: and so the word of Christ, when it has a fixed and established abode in a man's heart, he has an inward, spiritual, experimental knowledge of it; he is continually conversant with it; this word of Christ is his delight, and the men of his counsel his guide, his acquaintance, with whom he takes sweet counsel together, and esteems it above the most valuable things in the world, and receives and retains it as the word of God.

Paul's meaning of the term *richly* is, that not one part of the Scripture only should be regarded and attended to but the whole of it, every truth and doctrine in it, even the whole counsel of God; which as it is to be declared and preached in its utmost compass, so all and every part of it is to be received in the love of it,

To "let the word of Christ dwell in you *richly*" is to let it have ample room or remain as a rich treasure in the heart. We are to submit to the demands of the Christian message and let it become so deeply implanted within us as to control our thinking.

The early believers understood the words *In all wisdom* or "unto all wisdom" to mean that it came not as natural wisdom, which is not the design of the Scriptures, nor of the Gospel of Christ; but spiritual wisdom, or wisdom in spiritual things, in things relating to salvation; and which is, and may be arrived unto through attendance to the word of Christ, reading and hearing of it, meditating on it; and especially when accompanied with the spirit of wisdom and revelation in the knowledge of Christ,

"Teach and admonish one another" was meant to be done by private teaching, by conference, prayer, and singing the praises of God, according to the measure of the gift or grace bestowed on everyone.

By "psalms" he means all godly songs which were written upon various occasions, and by "hymns", all such as contain the praise of God, and by "spiritual songs", other more special and artful songs which were also in praise of God, but they were made fuller in music. Here Paul is simply emphasizing the rich variety in Christian song.

Singing was a vital part of the early church as a sincere expression of worship. It expressed real emotion of the heart, adoration and worship. They were to do it in a way worthy of their savior God.

Just as the early church saw worship as a sincere expression of the heart worship now means so much more. For the church today worship is the essences of our livelihood it is our

way of drawing closer to our Father God. Most of us will affirm that this is not an unfamiliar concept, yet there are times when we go home and rate the worship on a scale of 1-10. The question is not whether the worship service blessed me but whether if it blessed God. What matters is how God would rate our worship on His Scale of 1-10. Would he approve? Would he be pleased?

A great deal of interaction takes place vertically between us and God, but not much consideration takes place horizontal. These dynamics of praise comprise an integral part of the congregational experience. It is an element that is critical to the life of the believer, yet absent from one's personal devotional life.

We praise and worship in order to enhance the sense of unity within the body. Singing can in itself bring unity within a group, and in activity. Not only does worship cause us to grow in brotherly love it also gives us opportunity to minister to one another. We praise in order to teach and reinforce spiritual truth. We praise in order to declare the glories of God before unbelievers.

After having looked at worship from a vertical and horizontal stance let us now look at worship from an inward stance. One of the first thing inward worship does is it releases God's people to express their inner selves. We find that worship increases our faith and trust in God. It also helps us grow in holiness. Further it inspires a greater commitment to a life of worship. Finally, inward worship prepares us for the new thing God wants to do in us.

Many people in the world today are longing for fulfillment and are searching for it in all the wrong places. They will never find complete fulfillment in their innermost beings until they come into proper relationship with God through praise. "the purpose of God in sending his Son to die and live and be at the right hand of God the Father was that he might restore to us the missing jewel, the jewel of worship; that we might come back and learn to do again that which we were created to do in the first place-worship the Lord in the beauty of holiness." A.W. Tozer.